

counterbalance their absence. Once more, intensive enquiry is needed to support or dismiss such speculations.

Two other areas of enquiry require more detailed, intensive questioning of individuals; these are capital and income. So far we have not discovered a clear concept and word for capital among Chilwa fishermen as has been found in studies of other fishermen. Amongst Malay fishermen, for example, "the concept of capital as a stock of money used to finance production is quite a clear one.... It is described by the general term 'modal', and there is a definite idea that the 'modal' laid out on equipment such as boats or nets.... demands a specific return" (Firth 1966). Similarly, amongst the Ewe seine fishermen the same concept is 'agbadoho' which is "money set aside for business" or a separate central fund (Hill 1970).

A major and probably influential contrast of these two societies with Chilwa fishermen is that the former are both seacoast people who have been involved in large-scale and wide-ranging trade for generations. They have thus built up structures and attitudes that are of fairly recent origin around the landlocked and small Lake Chilwa. We have been able to trace in some cases, however, relation between initial and current capital equipment and how the initial capital was acquired (by farming, outside employment, or fishing). Also questions on the obstacles to success in fishing elicited an appreciation of a stock of good equipment and also of attitudinal qualities of business sense. A further clue is that some of the more highly capitalised fishermen are those who, during the drying of the lake, fished in other lakes, thus seeming to indicate an unwillingness to let capital lie idle. But more specific information on the sources of capital, the uses to which it is put, the relationship between the different investments, and the fishermen's attitudes to all these requires detailed enquiry on a personalised basis over time.

Questions on income are notoriously difficult in any social situation, but Chilwa provides even more problems. There is the fact of the lake drying and thus causing incomes to fluctuate widely; most fishermen sell fish by completely nonstandardised measures (in baskets, buckets, mats--all of varying size); prices vary from season to season and within seasons; catches vary according to weather, season, section of the lake, equipment, ability, and luck. Added to this is the usual reluctance to confide income figures to strangers, especially among the big fishermen who also may have fears of tax officers. Also, as pointed out above, the big fishermen tend to have a number of sources of income which all require enquiry before questions on expenditure, for example, can be useful. Therefore, although estimates of fishermen's income have been made and have indeed been

Since income was calculated from catch rates, such factors are significant. In one area fishermen gave the actual worth in shillings of each day's catch; in another they sold dried matemba by a standard bag. Hence, income estimates for these are more reliable. In other areas extreme variation of containers necessitated a series of estimates: (1) the amount of fish caught per container; (2) the translation of fresh into dried weight for certain fish per container; and (3) the translation into price. Although the greatest care was taken to achieve reliability in the calculations, the income figures projected from catch rates are only estimates.